Rising Prices Become a Big Issue in the US Midterm Elections

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Americans will vote in the **midterm elections** on November 3, less than three weeks away. These elections decide who controls the US **Congress**. Polls suggest that rising prices are on many voters' minds.

For nearly a year, President Donald Trump has tried to convince voters not to worry about prices. He has called concerns about **affordability** a "con job by Democrats." He has also said that gas and diesel prices, which rose sharply after the war with Iran began, would start falling soon. CBC News reported that Trump said consumer prices had fallen during his term, when they had actually risen.

Many voters do not seem convinced. On average, more than 70 percent of people in recent polls **disapprove** of how Trump has handled **inflation**, according to Silver Bulletin, which combines results from many polls. **Inflation** means prices going up over time.

New government data released on Wednesday showed that prices in September were 3.7 percent higher than a year earlier. Much of that rise came from fuel and clothing.

Spencer Kimball leads the Emerson College Polling Center in Boston. He said the economy is the top issue for voters, and that the cost of everyday things, rather than jobs or taxes, is driving their concerns. "It looks like it's just everyday expenses that are beginning to pile up," he told CBC News.

Trump has recently traveled to states such as Alaska, Kansas, Ohio and Texas to support Republican candidates for the US Senate. He won all of those states easily in 2024. Tim Malloy, a polling **analyst** at Quinnipiac University, called the trips "a last mad dash" to help Republican candidates who are now at risk largely because of cost-of-living worries.

Word Treasure

midterm elections -- US elections held halfway through a president's four-year term, mainly to choose members of Congress.

Congress -- The part of the US government that writes laws, made up of the Senate and the House of Representatives.

affordability -- How easy or hard it is for people to pay for the things they need.

inflation -- A general rise in prices over time, so the same money buys less.

disapprove -- To have a negative opinion about how something is being done.

analyst -- A person who studies information closely to explain what it means.

Background you need

In the United States, midterm elections happen between presidential elections, and voters choose members of the House of Representatives and about a third of the Senate.

Whichever party wins more seats controls Congress, which writes laws and can support or block a president's plans.

Inflation is measured by tracking the prices of common goods, such as fuel and clothing, and comparing them with a year earlier.

Polling groups ask many people the same questions so they can estimate what voters across the country think.

Break it down

LEAD: Rising prices are a top worry as Americans prepare to vote in the November 3 midterms
KEY EVENT: Polls show voters unhappy with how inflation has been handled
+- WHO: President Donald Trump, voters, Republican Senate candidates
+- WHAT: Trump has told voters not to worry, but most poll respondents disapprove
+- WHEN: Less than three weeks before the elections
EVIDENCE: September prices up 3.7 percent from a year earlier, mainly fuel and clothing; Silver Bulletin poll average above 70 percent disapproval
EXPERT VIEWS: Spencer Kimball says everyday costs drive concerns; Tim Malloy calls Trump's trips a last mad dash
OPEN QUESTION: Will cost-of-living worries change which party controls Congress?

Why it matters

Which party controls Congress affects the laws that are passed, and rising prices shape what families can afford every day.

Test what you remember

1. **When are the midterm elections in this article?**
   - (A) September 30
   - (B) November 3
   - (C) October 3
   - (D) December 3
2. **How much higher were prices in September than a year earlier?**
   - (A) 7.3 percent
   - (B) 1.5 percent
   - (C) 3.7 percent
   - (D) 70 percent
3. **Which two things drove much of the price rise?**
   - (A) Fuel and clothing
   - (B) Cars and phones
   - (C) Toys and books
   - (D) Food and housing
4. **According to Silver Bulletin, about what share of people in recent polls disapprove of Trump's handling of inflation?**
   - (A) Fewer than 30 percent
   - (B) About half
   - (C) Nearly everyone
   - (D) More than 70 percent
5. **What did Spencer Kimball say is driving voters' economic worries?**
   - (A) The cost of everyday things
   - (B) Jobs
   - (C) Taxes
   - (D) Interest rates
6. **How did Tim Malloy describe Trump's recent trips?**
   - (A) A victory tour
   - (B) A vacation
   - (C) A fundraising drive
   - (D) A last mad dash

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: A 4: D 5: A 6: D

Questions to think about

1. President Donald Trump: Has called affordability concerns a con job by Democrats and said gas and diesel prices would fall soon.

2. Spencer Kimball, Emerson College Polling: Says the economy is voters' top issue, driven by everyday costs rather than jobs or taxes.

3. Tim Malloy, Quinnipiac University: Says Trump's trips are a last mad dash to help Republican candidates now at risk over cost-of-living worries.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):